CP 104:2 (2009)

A HIPPONACTEAN ECHO IN CATULLUS (*FRIGUS*, 44.20)

Catullan commentary has had little to say about Hipponax, beyond superficial references to the traditional metrical background of Catullus' choliambics.[1] When the pre-Callimachean Greek iambic tradition is invoked, Hipponax typically (and not without reason) receives second billing to Archilochus.[2] Nevertheless, the "colore ipponatteo" of Catullan (as well as Lucilian and Horatian) invective has been clearly established, even if demonstrable Hipponactean verbal reminiscences are somewhat elusive, and even if some of the "Hipponactean" coloration must be attributed to the mediating influence of Callimachus.[3] As for the meter, one may say that Catullan choliambic poetry adopts not merely the Hipponactean metrical framework,[4] but also the ethos of the Greek poet's use of the meter. This correlation has been perceptively signaled by Douglas Thomson, who has emphasized that Catullus "uses the choliambic metre . . . as a rule . . . for serious attacks."[5]

The Hipponactean ethos can be discerned far more broadly in Catullus' handling of characteristic themes and topoi, as discussed by Massimo Lenchantin de Gubernatis and others. One such recurring topos involves the discomforts of cold, as in fragments 42 Dg (32 W), 43 Dg (34 W), 61 Dg (59 W), and 194.9–11 Dg (115.9–11 W). Despite the silence of commentators on this connection, it is worth considering the possibility of a Hipponactean background to Catullus' choliambic Poem 44, the ostensible subject of which is his *gravedo frigida*, accompanied by a *frequens tussis*.

1. Citations of the fragments of Hipponax use the text and numeration of Degani 1983 (hereafter, Dg; texts, with notes and translations, also available in Degani 2007), together with the numeration of West 1989 (W). Translations are from West 1994.

Let it be recalled that choliambic meter might well have been used before Hipponax, despite frequent assertions (e.g., Courtney 1993, 105, or Godwin 1999, 6, 19) that Hipponax "invented" the scazon. As rightly observed by Masson (1962, 22, with earlier references), the traditional attribution of priority to Hipponax "sert surtout à montrer quel est l'écrivain qui a illustré le premier ce type de vers. Au-delà d'Hipponax, le problème est insoluble."

2. E.g., Syndikus 1984, 211 (ad Catull. 37), 221 (ad 40), 285 n. 2 (ad 59). A rare exception (192, ad 33): "Diebes- und Lumpenmilieu kennt man seit Hipponax als Thema jambischer Dichtung." In a more extended compass: Wray 2001, 167–89, on "Archilochian" modes of invective in Catullus.

3. On Catullus and Alexandrian choliambic poetry, see, e.g., Syndikus 1984, 41. The Italian phrase derives from chapter 9 ("Colore ipponatteo della poesia catulliana") of Lenchantin de Gubernatis 1933, lxxxvii–lxxxix. For a balanced discussion of the issue, see Degani 1984, 67–68, with further references, among which Koenen (1977) deserves special mention, despite the uncertainty of some of his specific textual claims; see the critique by Degani (1981), as well as Degani 1993. Rosen (1988, 35 n. 23) discusses possible parallels between Catullus and Hipponax frag. 20 Dg (12 W).

4. With, as is well known, variations derived from Callimachus' practice; on the most salient (i.e., the disallowed spondaic variant preceding the final two syllables), see Courtney 1993, 105 (ad Matius frag. 16).

5. Thomson 1997, 346 (ad Catull. 60); similarly 259 (ad 22), and further 284 (ad 31, the only real exception to this generalization; on this problem see also Syndikus 1984, 189).

To be sure, Catullus engages here in some complex and un-Hipponactean forms of parody, and it is widely agreed that this incorporates a literary-critical barb against the "frigidity" of the oration by Sestius referred to in the poem.[6] Still, just as Hipponax laments his bursting chilblains (frag. 43.4 Dg, 34.4 W), Catullus pointedly refers to his cough, with forms of *tussis* repeated three times in line-final position: *expuli tussim* (44.7), *frequens tussis* (44.13), *gravedinem et tussim* (44.19). John Godwin is almost alone among commentators to have noted that the appearance of *tussis* in just this metrical locus is a highly effective touch[7]—that is, so to speak, exactly where the regular iambic rhythm suddenly coughs up a trochee.[8] The same touch appears in a choliambic poem of Martial, where the full stop preceding the line-final *tussit* reinforces the effect by marked syntactic means (*quid ergo in illa petitur et placet? tussit*, 1.10.4).[9] The technique of pointing up loaded words by line-final position[10] (and sometimes poem-final position) is far from isolated in Catullan choliambics: two of the most "Hipponactean" of Catullus' abusive choliambics end with a word meaning "urine": *et dens Hibera defricatus* ***urina*** (37.20), *hoc te amplius bibisse praedicet* ***loti*** (39.21)—and the fixation of Hipponax with bodily effusions (including urine) hardly requires detailed comment.[11]

It may be objected that the chill of winter is not the same as the chill of a head cold; and yet "cold" is "cold." The freighted word *frigus* in this poem (cf. *gravedo frigida*, 44.13) appears line-finally at 44.20 (following the final cough in 44.19), the next-to-last line of the poem, and is highlighted by alliteration and assonance: *non mihi, sed ipsi Sestio ferat* ***frigus***. Compare, first of all, the full context of the Hipponax fragment referring to chilblains, mentioned above (frag. 43 Dg, 34 W):

ἐμοὶ γὰρ οὐκ ἔδωκας οὔτέ κω χλαῖναν
δασεῖαν ἐν χειμῶνι φάρμακον **ῥίγεος**,
οὔτ' ἀσκέρητισι τοὺς πόδας δασείητισι
ἔκρυψας, ὥς μοι μὴ χίμετλα ῥήγνυται.

6. See especially Fordyce 1961, 197–98; on various levels of literary parody (disputing Fordyce's judgment that "[t]he piece is merely a vehicle for the pun on *frigus*," and with particular reference to earlier work by Heusch and Ronconi on the marked use of archaisms in the poem), see Jones 1968.

7. See Godwin 1999, 163, on the "expressive language" in 44.13–14, including the "emphasised onomatopeic final word *tussis*" at 44.13.

8. As pointed out to me some years ago by David Coffin (Phillips Exeter Academy), the regular spacing of the intervals at which this *frequens tussis* erupts is also iconically effective (an observation I have not seen elsewhere).

9. The parallel with Catullus is noted neither by Howell (1980) nor by Swann (1994). On this placement of the pointed "paradox" at the end of Martial's scazons (like *tussit*, 1.10.4, *pallet*, 1.77.1–6, *laudes*, 1.89.6), see Tanner 1986, 2645 with n. 40, though one need not accept Tanner's (to my mind improbable) metrical etiology of this feature, involving a Saturnian intermediary affecting Roman adaptation of the Greek scazon.

10. The locus, predictably, of a pun in Antiphanes (frag. 225 KA, line 7) recently studied by Leigh (2004), where the analysis turns precisely on the possibility of scanning an iambic trimeter as a scazon, given an ambiguous vowel quantity in the line-final word.

11. For urination and defecation, see, e.g., frags. 73 Dg (73 W): ὦμειξε δ' αἷμα καὶ χολὴν ἐτίλησεν, 79.6 Dg (79.6 W):]κάνετίλησε[, 95.9 Dg (92.9 W): παραψι{δ}άζων βολβίτωι[, 138 Dg (144 W): βολβίτου κασιγνήτην. The repeated reference to teeth in Catullus 39 (cf. also 37.20; on this motif in 39.20, see Katz 2000) calls to mind recurring Hipponactean dental motifs, including (1) the teeth themselves (frags. 132 Dg [73.4 W]: ὀδόντες [line-final in West's reconstruction], 194.11 [115.11 W]: ὀδόντας, and possibly 95.13 Dg [92.13 W]: ὀδ.[); (2) gnashing (frag. 107.15 Dg [104.15 W]: ἐπιβρύκων [line-final]); (3) gnawing (frags. 32 Dg [66 W]: τρώγει [line-final], 36.5 Dg [26.5 W]: τρώγων [line-final]; and (4) biting (frags. 39.6 Dg [28.6 W]: δάκηι, 86.11 Dg [84.11 W]: ἐδάκνομεν).

For thou hast never granted me a cloak
thick in the winter to cure me of the shivers,
nor hast thou wrapped my feet in thick fur boots
to stop my chilblains bursting.

Thus line-final ῥίγεος (disyllabic, with synizesis) is metrically and (apart from the case form) lexically equivalent to *frigus* in Catullus 44.20.[12] Nor is this the only such instance in Hipponax: the metrical/lexical equation is reinforced by a second line-final disyllabic occurrence of a form based on ῥιγ- (in this instance a verb form), in a fragment of very similar content (frag. 42a.2–4 Dg [32.2–4 W]), or, following West, from another part of the same poem:

ἐπεύχομαί τοι κάρτα γὰρ κακῶς ῥιγῶ
καὶ βαμβαλύζω . . .
δὸς χλαῖναν Ἱππώνακτι καὶ κυπασσίσκον

hear thou my prayer, for I am bloody frozen,
my teeth are chattering . . .
Grant Hipponax a cloak and a nice tunic

In the end, little of the "colore ipponatteo" in fact remains in Catullus' typically sophisticated composition. What does remain—just barely—is a faint but clear lexical and metrical echo of the *mot clé* of this prominent Hipponactean topos.

Brent Vine
University of California, Los Angeles

12. It can hardly be doubted that the phonetic and semantic similarities (as well as that involving gender) between Gk. ῥῖγος and Lat. *frigus*—far tighter than many of the Graeco-Latin etymologies retailed by Varro—would have been striking to Catullus. Whether he would have appreciated the words' actual linguistic cognacy in something like the modern sense is beside the point, as is the fact that the *literary* pun involving Lat. *frigidus/frigus* (n. 6 above) is based on other Greek vocabulary (ψυχρός, ψυχρότης).

LITERATURE CITED

Courtney, E. 1993. *The Fragmentary Latin Poets*. Oxford.
Degani, E. 1981. Ipponatte nella letteratura latina. *RivFil* 109: 385–406.
———, ed. 1983. *Hipponactis Testimonia et Fragmenta*. Leipzig.
———. 1984. *Studi su Ipponatte*. Bari.
———. 1993. Orazio e la tradizione giambica greca. In *Letture oraziane*, ed. G. Bruno, 83–89. Venosa.
———, ed. and trans. 2007. *Ipponatte: Frammenti*. Bologna.
Fordyce, C. J. 1961. *Catullus: A Commentary*. Oxford.
Godwin, J., ed. and trans. 1999. *Catullus: The Shorter Poems*. Warminster.
Howell, P. 1980. *A Commentary on Book One of the "Epigrams" of Martial*. London.
Jones, C. P. 1968. Parody in Catullus 44. *Hermes* 96: 379–83.
Katz, J. T. 2000. Egnatius' Dental Fricatives (Catullus 39.20). *CP* 95: 338–48.
Koenen, L. 1977. Horaz, Catull und Hipponax. *ZPE* 26: 73–93.
Leigh, M. 2004. A Pun in Antiphanes (fr. 225 K-A = Ath. 60C-D). *CQ* 54: 278–83.
Lenchantin de Gubernatis, M., ed. 1933. *Il libro di Catullo*. Turin.
Masson, O., ed. 1962. *Les fragments du poète Hipponax*. Paris.
Rosen, R. 1988. Hipponax, Boupalos, and the Conventions of the *Psogos*. *TAPA* 118: 29–41.

Swann, B. W. 1994. *Martial's Catullus: The Reception of an Epigrammatic Rival*. Hildesheim.
Syndikus, H. P. 1984. *Catull: Eine Interpretation*. Vol. 1. Darmstadt.
Tanner, R. G. 1986. Levels of Intent in Martial. *ANRW* 32.4: 2624–77.
Thomson, D. F. S. 1997. *Catullus*. Toronto.
West, M. L. 1989. *Iambi et Elegi Graeci*^{2}. Vol. 1. Oxford.
_____, trans. 1994. *Greek Lyric Poetry: A New Translation*. Oxford.
Wray, D. 2001. *The Poetics of Roman Manhood*. Cambridge.